

■ By Abhishek Sharan

The date: July 17, 2006. The place: Mantralaya, Mumbai. It was just seven days after the BDX cocktail bombs killed 192 people in the Mumbai serial train blasts. You could sense the tension in the air. R.R. Patil, deputy chief minister and in charge of the state Home Ministry was furious. Around him were the state's Director General of Police P.S. Pasricha and the State Intelligence Department's (SID) Commissioner A.P. Dhare, among others. Patil demanded an answer to SID's failure to detect the elaborate preparations that must have preceded the terror attack. Dhare knew the music had just begun. His team had not been able to detect a sleeper module of 11 Pakistani operatives, which had been in the city for months, assembling bombs and surveying the rail network.

A grim-faced Patil asked, "What can be done to make sure that SID does not slip up in the future?" And for the first time in that meeting, Dhare, who had held several brainstorming sessions with his own department heads, had his answer—SID needed an urgent makeover. The department had become an abode of demotivated stragglers. He stressed the need for permanent, specially-trained officers to plug in the lacuna since deputed officers could not be motivated to give their best in what was widely seen to be a temporary posting.

This proposal was granted an in-principle approval by Patil at the meeting itself. However, he asked Dhare to prepare a formal proposal for home ministry's perusal. The detailed proposal was submitted in October 2006. The government took around eight months to formally sanc-

SLEEPING OVER INTELLIGENCE



Despite a looming terror threat, the state SID's makeover plan is yet to take off even after 15 months of the government approval

tion it after seeking the required approval of the state cabinet and the legislative assembly. On June 2, it issued a resolution outlining the makeover plan and allocated Rs 42.66 crore for the facelift, out of which Rs 40.43 will be spent on the salaries. It also permitted the recruitment of 24 senior intelligence officers and 109 assistant intelligence officers by the state public service commission (PSC) and SID, respectively—all this, without any stipulated time period.

That was then. Sixteen months since the "in-principle approval" and a year since Dhare submitted the detailed proposal, the new, reconstituted SID is still an idea buried in the files of the Mantralaya. "No particular time-frame was given to the makeover's implementation. We were looking at six months, but yes, it's been 16 months," says Chandrakant Dalvi, deputy-secretary in the state home ministry.

Reason for the delay: all ideas are caught between intention and action. So far, no recruitments have been done for SID as the state PSC is yet to receive the state government's sanction for it. This can be done only when it is notified in the gazette; the new recruitment and service rules currently being framed by the General Administration Department (GAD) are to be vetted by the state law ministry which would then hand the proposal back to the state home ministry. When asked whether the delay was because of GAD and the state law ministry, Dalvi said, "It will not be



"Reconstituting SID is my dream project. It is a huge challenge and needs time."

R.R. PATIL
DEPUTY CHIEF MINISTER